



DECK# Annotation Guide

How to physically prepare your DECK# deck

Version: 1

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What you need

- A standard French-suited playing card deck (52 cards + 2 Jokers)
- A fine-tip black permanent marker
- A fine-tip red permanent marker
- The annotation matrix (section 13 of the specification, or the `decksharp_matrix.csv` file)

Estimated time: 15–20 minutes.

Before you begin

The DECK# deck is annotated **once**, before any play session. Annotations are permanent. There is no in-game annotation: variable states are managed with physical tokens (dice, tokens, coins).

Each card receives four types of annotation, in distinct zones:

Annotation	Zone	Tool
Quadrant markers	Back	Black marker
Connectivity markers	Physical edges (front face)	Black marker
Orientation dot (north pole)	SE corner (front face)	Black marker
Primary glyph + modifier	S/N and NE/SW zones (front face)	Black or red (see below)

Color rule: glyph color is always contrasting relative to the card's suit. - Red cards (♥ ♦) → glyphs in **black** - Black cards (♣ ♠) → glyphs in **red**

Glyph color is not a choice: it is automatically derived from suit.

Preparation: sorting the deck

Separate the deck into three groups:

1. **Red cards** (♥ ♦) — 26 cards
2. **Black cards** (♣ ♠) — 26 cards
3. **Jokers** — 2 cards, set aside

Work first on **red cards**: they require only the black marker for all annotation. Then proceed to **black cards**: they require a tool switch only in the final phase (glyphs in red). Handle **Jokers** last — they have minimal, separate annotation.

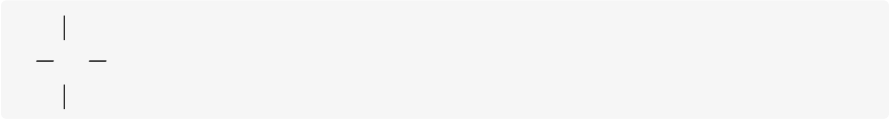
Phase 1 — Quadrant markers (back)

Tool: black marker.

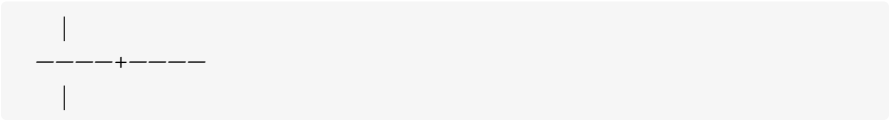
With cards oriented face-down, draw quadrant markers on all 54 cards (red + black + Jokers).

Quadrant markers are identical on all cards and indicate the center and sides of the card to the player when it is placed face-down on the table. Choose one of the two variants and keep it consistent throughout the deck:

Minimal variant — four short segments starting from the midpoint of each edge toward the center, without crossing it:



Extended variant — full cross from edge to edge:



Allow the ink to dry before flipping the cards.



Phase 2 — Connectivity markers (edges)

Tool: black marker.

Consult the annotation matrix. For each card, the **Connectivity** column indicates which edges are **open** (connected). Edges not listed receive a **wall marker**: a thick line drawn along the external white margin of the card (~3–4 mm), on the front face.

Example: if the matrix shows N+W, the North and West edges are open — leave them unmarked. The South and East edges receive the wall marker.

Allow a few seconds of drying time between cards before stacking them.



Phase 3 — Orientation dot (north pole)

Tool: black marker.

Draw a small dot • in the far lower right corner of each card — the **SE** zone of the front face. This dot breaks the vertical symmetry of standard cards and indicates the north pole: the side with the pre-printed index at top left (NW).

The dot goes on all 52 standard cards and both Jokers.

Phase 4 — Primary glyphs and modifiers

Tool: black marker for red cards (♥ ♦) · red marker for black cards (♣ ♠).

Consult the annotation matrix. For each card, annotate:

- **Primary glyph** in the **S** zone (lower middle edge, inside the card) and its rotated mirror in the **N** zone (upper middle edge).
- **Modifier glyph** in the **NE** corner (upper right corner) and its rotated mirror in the **SW** zone (lower left corner).

The mirror positions (N and SW) make the card readable in a fan, regardless of orientation in hand.

The DECK# vocabulary comprises seven glyphs:

Glyph	How to draw it
• dot	a single dot
— line	a horizontal line
+ cross	two perpendicular lines
× diagonal	two diagonal lines
△ triangle	three strokes
○ circle	a closed ring
□ square	four strokes

Exception: Jokers

The two Jokers receive the **quadrant marker** on the back (Phase 1, identical to the 52 standard cards) and the **orientation dot** in the SE zone (Phase 3). No connectivity markers, no primary glyph, no modifier.

They are uninstantiated variables: each game decides whether and how to use them.

Summary chart per card

Element	Position	52	standard cards	2 Jokers
Quadrant markers	Back		✓	✓
Connectivity markers	Front face edges	✓ (from matrix)		—
North pole dot	SE corner front face		✓	✓
Primary glyph	S + N zones front face	✓ (from matrix)		—
Modifier glyph	NE + SW zones front face	✓ (from matrix)		—

How to read the annotation matrix

The matrix lists all 54 cards with three pieces of information:

- **Connectivity:** open edges, in N/S/E/W notation separated by +. Edges not listed receive the wall marker.
- **Primary:** the glyph to draw in the S zone (and its mirror in N).
- **Modifier:** the glyph to draw in the NE zone (and its mirror in SW).

Glyph color is not in the matrix because it is always derived from suit: black for ♥/♦, red for ♣/♠.

DECK#

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